

The Lamp in the Attic

Written by

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A short film rolled with storywheel

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FADE IN:

EXT. HOLLOWAY HOUSE - NIGHT

Rain hammers a tall, narrow house at the end of a lane. Every window is dark except one: a small round window under the roof, where a lamp burns.

MARA HOLLOWAY (40s, coat soaked through, a ring of keys in her fist) stands at the gate.

MARA (V.O.)  
I told myself I would never come back. Not for the funeral. Not for the house. Not for anything that was left in it.

She opens the gate. It shrieks.

INT. HOLLOWAY HOUSE - HALLWAY - CONTINUOUS

Dust sheets over everything. Mara finds a light switch. Nothing.

MARA  
(under her breath)  
Of course.

VOICE (O.S.)  
Close the door, Mara. You're letting the cold in.

Mara freezes. Turns slowly toward the stairs.

MARA  
Who's there?

Silence. Then, very faintly, a door closes somewhere above her.

MARA (CONT'D)  
I have a phone. I'm calling the police.

She does not take out her phone.

INT. HOLLOWAY HOUSE - ATTIC - NIGHT

A low room under the eaves. Boxes, a rocking horse, a dressmaker's dummy. In the middle of the floor, on a tea chest, the lamp: brass, polished, burning steadily.

Beside it sits BRAM ASHER (70s, cardigan, carpet slippers), the old neighbor. He doesn't look surprised to see her.

BRAM  
You took your time.

MARA  
What are you doing in my  
mother's house?

BRAM  
Keeping the lamp lit. Same as every  
night for thirty-one years. She  
asked me to, the week your father  
left, and I said I would, and I'm  
not a man who stops doing a thing  
just because the person who asked  
him has gone and died on him. You'd  
know that if you'd ever once come  
home. Every night at nine I come up  
those stairs, I wipe the glass, I  
trim the wick, and I sit with it  
until it's steady. And every night  
I think, this is the night Mara  
comes back. Thirty-one years of  
nights. So yes. You took your time.

Mara sits down on a box. The light goes out of her.

MARA  
Why the lamp?

BRAM  
(a long look at her)  
So you'd know where the house was.  
In the dark.

CUT TO:

THE NEXT MORNING

EXT. HOLLOWAY HOUSE - GARDEN - DAY

Wet grass. A FOR SALE sign leans against the wall. Mara, in last night's clothes, drinks coffee from a jar.

An ESTATE AGENT (30s, relentlessly cheerful) picks his way across the lawn.

ESTATE AGENT

Lovely bones. Lovely, lovely bones.  
We'll want the attic cleared, of  
course. Buyers don't like to see a  
lamp burning in an empty house.  
Gives them ideas.

MARA

What ideas?

ESTATE AGENT

(laughing)

That somebody's still home.

Mara looks up. The round window. The lamp, burning in daylight.

INT. HOLLOWAY HOUSE - ATTIC - DAY

Mara alone with the lamp. She reaches for it, hesitates, and turns the little brass key that lowers the wick.

The flame does not go down.

She turns the key the whole way. The flame stays exactly where it is.

MARA

Mum?

The lamp flickers once.

MARA (CONT'D)

(quietly)

I'm here. I came back.

*Hush now, the lamp is lit,  
the house is warm, and you are in it.*

She knows the song. She sings the next line under her breath without meaning to.

DISSOLVE TO:

INT. HOLLOWAY HOUSE - KITCHEN - NIGHT

Bram and Mara at the kitchen table, a bottle of whisky between them.

BRAM  
She never blamed you.

MARA  
She should have.

BRAM  
Well. She didn't.

FADE OUT.